



2.c) Critically examine Phenomenological approach in Anthropological studies. (15 marks)

Phenomenological approach is the study of phenomena or subjective experience of people from the native's point of view.

Brief Background

The approach of phenomenology arose in response to the positivist approach of schools like evolutionism and functionalism which aimed at objectivity and etic perspective. Phenomenology on the other hand emphasises on subjective experience and emic perspective.

Approach of Phenomenology

→ It highlights that people's culture reflects their subjective experience of viewing the outside world.

→ it suggests that there is no objective reality and what we see and experience is very subjective.

→ it prescribes against making any universal laws of culture.

Examples of Phenomenology

① Kliffon Geertz Interpretive approach says that anthropology is not a science in search of laws rather an analysis & in search of meaning.

→ he emphasised on ethnographers to get into the shoes of the natives and present a thick description from native's view.

② Cognitive Anthropology led by Harold Conklin and Stephen Tyler too emphasizes on phenomenology by focussing on learning native cultural categories.

Merits of approach

- ① It presents the native's point view.
- ② It helps in removing the biases of the ethnographers.
- ③ The ethnographic research is more closer to the lived experiences of the native's.

Limitations

- ① It is too subjective and difficult to empirically verify.
- ② Makes it difficult to draw generalisations and develop a science of culture.
- ③ Time consuming as learning native's categorisation ~~may be~~ from their language may be different.

Despite all limitations, phenomenology is widely used in ethnographic research today.